

That said, as a programmer, you should be familiar with the basics of what classes are and how they work. In this chapter, you'll learn what classes are, why they're used in programs, and the syntax and programming concepts behind them. OOP is a broad topic, and this chapter acts only as an introduction.

Real-World Analogy: Filling Out a Form

You've most likely had to fill out paper or electronic forms numerous times in your life: for doctor's visits, for online purchases, or to RSVP to a wedding. Forms exist as a uniform way for another person or organization to collect the information they need about you. Different forms ask for different kinds of information. You would report a sensitive medical condition on a doctor's form, and you would report any guests you're bringing on a wedding RSVP, but not the other way around.

In Python, *class*, *type*, and *data type* have the same meaning. Like a paper or electronic form, a *class* is a blueprint for Python *objects* (also called *instances*), which contain the data that represents a noun. This noun could be a doctor's patient, an ecommerce purchase, or a wedding guest. Classes are like a blank form template, and the objects created from that class are like filled-out forms that contain actual data about the kind of thing the form represents. For example, in [Figure 15-1](#), the RSVP response form is like a class, whereas the filled-out RSVP is like an object.